The NYC School System

Applying to school,
starting at age 4



Warm-up

Where are these schools?



A



B



C



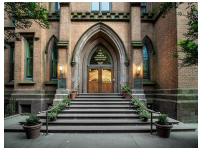
D



E

Which of these are actually in New York? Why do you think so?

They're all in New York City



Packer Collegiate



Nightingale-Bamford



Trinity School



Stuyvesant



Bronx Science

- **A, B, C:** private schools. Tuition: about **$69,000 a year** (Trinity, 2025–26)
- **D, E:** public schools. Tuition: **$0**, but you need a top score on an entrance exam
- In 2026–27, at least **seven** NYC private schools charge more than **$70,000 a year**

Sources: Fortune, Feb. 2025; Bloomberg, Feb. 2026. Photos: Ajay Suresh, CC BY 2.0 (Packer, Nightingale-Bamford); Jay Dobkin, CC BY-SA 4.0 (Trinity); Kidfly182, CC BY-SA 4.0 (Stuyvesant); Bxsstudent, public domain (Bronx Science). All via Wikimedia Commons.

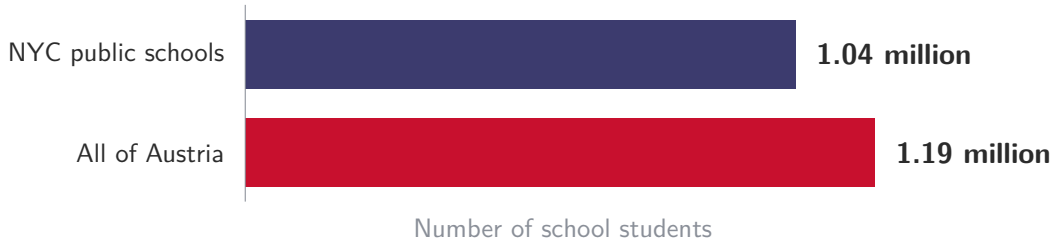
Basic Info

NYC schools by the numbers

- **About 885,000** students in NYC Public Schools (3-K to 12th grade, 2025–26)
- **Plus about 151,000** in public charter schools (publicly funded, privately run)
- **1,599** schools run by NYC Public Schools
- **Roughly 200,000** in private schools, most of them religious (Jewish and Catholic)
- About **73%** of public school students live in poverty; **14%** are homeless or in temporary housing

Sources: NYC Public Schools, *Data at a Glance* (2025–26); NYC Comptroller, *Tracking the K-12 Student Population in NYC* (Oct. 2026).

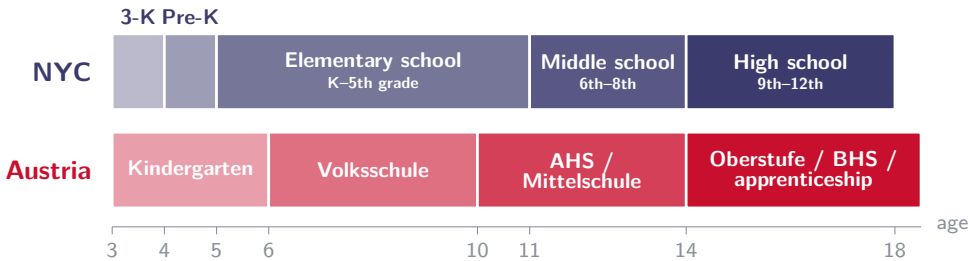
One city, one country



NYC's public schools are almost as big as Austria's entire school system.

Sources: NYC Public Schools (2025–26, district + charter schools); Statistik Austria via ORF (2024/25: 1,185,525 students).

The basic structure



- In NYC, 3-K and Pre-K are free, but not compulsory

The Path to College

Remember: getting into college



Fewer than 1 in 20 applicants get in.

Sources: Yale News, Mar. 2026 (2,328 of 54,919); Columbia via *Columbia Spectator* (2,581 of 61,031); *Harvard Crimson*, Oct. 2025 (Class of 2029: 2,003 of 47,893).

But. . .

- Most American colleges admit most students who apply
- More than half of four-year colleges accept **two-thirds** or more of applicants
- Only **17** of about 1,364 four-year colleges accepted fewer than **10%**
- The pressure is about getting into the top schools, and in NYC that race starts early

Source: Pew Research Center, 2019 (data for 2017).

For NYC students, the application process begins in pre-K.

Applying to elementary school

- Every 5-year-old in NYC is guaranteed a kindergarten seat, but not at a specific school
- Families rank schools; if a school has more applicants than seats, there's a lottery
- Who gets priority (in order):

  1. Live in the school's **zone** and have a **sibling** there
  2. Live in the school's **zone**
  3. Have a **sibling** at the school (but live outside the zone)
  4. Attend the school's **pre-K**

Source: NYC Public Schools, kindergarten admissions (fall 2027 cycle).

Gifted and Talented (G&T)

- Separate, accelerated classes, starting in kindergarten
- About **2,500** kindergarten seats a year; about 18,000 G&T students in total
- How do 4-year-olds get in?
  - Public pre-K students: their **pre-K teacher** evaluates them
  - Private pre-K or no pre-K: an **interview** with the Education Department
  - Eligible children then enter a **lottery**
- Until 2021, children took a test at age 4
- **Mayor Mamdani** wants to stop admitting kindergartners to G&T; for now the program continues (fall 2027 applications open Dec. 2026)

Sources: NYC Public Schools, Gifted and Talented; AP and news reports, 2025–26.

Elementary school

- School day: about **8:30 a.m. to 3:00 p.m.** (6 hours 20 minutes; times vary by school)
- One main teacher, one classroom, the same classmates all day
- Subjects: Math, English Language Arts (ELA), Science, Social Studies, Spanish, Music, Technology
- After **5th grade** (age 10–11): you must apply to middle school

Source: Chalkbeat, Apr. 2026 (length of the school day).

Applying to middle school

- Apply in the fall of 5th grade and rank schools in order of preference
- Some schools use a lottery with priorities (e.g. living in the district)
- Others screen students using **4th-grade report card grades**
- This is when many families **leave** the public schools: the biggest drop in enrollment happens between 5th and 6th grade
- Example: my middle school, **MS 54 Booker T. Washington** (Upper West Side): ms54.org/admissions

Sources: NYC Public Schools, middle school admissions; NYC Comptroller, Oct. 2026.

Watch: a school tour

Watch:

Elster school tour

Applying to High School

Three separate applications

- **1. Specialized High Schools** (8 schools): admission by one test only, the SHSAT
  - e.g. Stuyvesant, Bronx Science, Brooklyn Tech
- **2. LaGuardia High School** (performing and visual arts): admission by audition or portfolio
- **3. The main application:** 700+ programs at 400+ high schools
  - **Screened** programs: grades, attendance, sometimes interviews
  - **Audition** programs, e.g. Frank Sinatra School of the Arts
  - **Open** programs: lottery
- Each application can give you at most one offer

Source: NYC Public Schools, high school admissions.

Happening right now

- This month, about **26,000** NYC 8th graders take the SHSAT
  - Test days: **Nov. 14/15 and 21, 2026**
- High school applications are due **Dec. 4, 2026**
- Offers arrive **March 3, 2027**

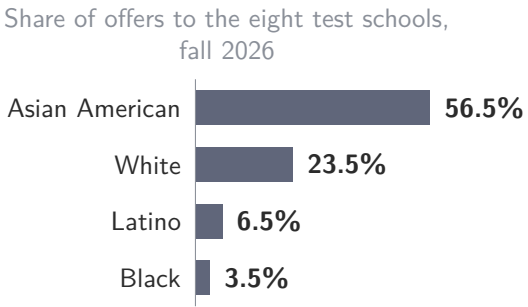
Source: NYC Public Schools, fall 2027 admissions calendar.

The SHSAT

- **3 hours**, **100 questions** (50 English, 50 Math), no calculator
- New in 2026: taken on a computer, and adaptive: get a question right and the next one is harder
- Your score is the only thing that counts. No grades, no interviews, no essays
- About **26,100** students took it last year; about **4,000** got an offer (about **1 in 6**)
- Lowest score that got into Stuyvesant: **561** (2026 admissions)

Sources: NYC Public Schools, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions*; Chalkbeat, July 2026.

Who gets in?



- Stuyvesant offered seats to **3** Black students
- **Supporters** of the test: it's objective, the same rules for everyone
- **Critics**: it favors families who can pay for test prep and leaves out Black and Latino students
- Mayor Mamdani has said he will **keep** the test and study it for bias

Source: Chalkbeat, July 2026.

No guarantee

- Applying to all three is far from a guarantee
- At my middle school, about **30 students** got **no** high school offer at all in the first round
- There's usually no "default" school: most NYC high schools aren't zoned
- Students without an offer go on **waitlists** and are placed later at a school with open seats
- Citywide (2024): about **3%** of applicants got no offer to any school on their list

Source: NYC Public Schools, 2024 admissions cycle data release.

What does high school look like?

- Highly dependent on which school you go to
- Some schools have **thousands** of students; others fewer than **150**
- Specialized schools: very competitive, lots of homework, many AP courses
- Small schools: themes like law, health, technology, or the arts

My high school

- About **150 students per grade**
- An "Early College" program: college courses during high school, for free college credit
- A **5-story** building

> Take a look:
> Google Street View

My schedule

Period	Monday		Tuesday		Wednesday		Thursday		Friday	
2	ZJS42U/3 First Year Semi MATTHEWS	Room REM 9:55-10:45	ZJS42U/3 First Year Semi MATTHEWS	Room REM 9:55-10:45	PFS11Q1Y/3 Introduction to ARPAIO	Room REM 9:55-10:45	ZJS42U/3 First Year Semi MATTHEWS	Room REM 9:55-10:45	ZJS42U/3 First Year Semi MATTHEWS	Room REM 9:55-10:45
3			MCS21U/1 Calculus I DANQUAH	Room REM 10:50-11:40	MCS21U/1 Calculus I DANQUAH	Room REM 10:50-11:40	MCS21U/1 Calculus I DANQUAH	Room REM 10:50-11:40	MCS21U/1 Calculus I DANQUAH	Room REM 10:50-11:40
4	EES11UDQ/1 Cervantes Don Q HINRICHS	Room REM 11:45-12:35	EES11UDQ/1 Cervantes Don Q HINRICHS	Room REM 11:45-12:35	EES11UDQ/1 Cervantes Don Q HINRICHS	Room REM 11:45-12:35	EES11UDQ/1 Cervantes Don Q HINRICHS	Room REM 11:45-12:35	GAS86/7 CTO Advisory NOLAN	Room REM 11:45-12:35
5										
6	FLS42U/1 Latin 104 CLARK	Room REM 1:35- 2:25			FLS42U/1 Latin 104 CLARK	Room REM 1:35- 2:25	FLS42U/1 Latin 104 CLARK	Room REM 1:35- 2:25	FLS42U/1 Latin 104 CLARK	Room REM 1:35- 2:25
7	SBS22U/4 Intro General B ILBOUDO	Room REM 2:30- 3:20	SBS22U/4 Intro General B ILBOUDO	Room REM 2:30- 3:20	SBS22U/4 Intro General B ILBOUDO	Room REM 2:30- 3:20			SBS22U/4 Intro General B ILBOUDO	Room REM 2:30- 3:20
8										
9					ZQWT/33 Writing and Thi ILBOUDO	Room REM 4:20- 5:10				

College-level courses: Calculus I, Latin, Intro to General Biology, Cervantes' *Don Quixote*

Next step: college

- At my school, getting A's was relatively easy
- So: "spam" extracurriculars, i.e. do as many as you can
- Popular activities at my school:
  - **Clubs:** Quiz Bowl, Model UN, Debate
  - **Sports:** Frisbee, Tennis

Compare

Sorting students: NYC vs. Austria

	NYC	Austria
First selection	G&T at **4–5**	Gymnasium (AHS) or Mittelschule at **10**
Middle school	Apply at **10–11** (lottery or grades)	Based on Volksschule grades
High school	Apply at **13–14**; one test for the top 8 schools	Oberstufe, BHS (HTL, HAK . . .) or apprenticeship at **14**
Private schools	Many, up to **$70,000+** a year	Mostly Catholic, far cheaper
University	Applications, essays, tests; under 5% at top schools	Matura, then mostly **open** admission; free for EU students (within standard study time)

Sources: NYC Public Schools; oesterreich.gv.at; studium.at.

Think

Austria is often criticized for sorting kids at 10.
Is New York better or worse?

Final Activity

Could you get into Stuyvesant?

- In your groups: answer **5 real questions** from the official SHSAT guide
- No calculators!
- Write down your answers; we'll check them after each question
- Real 8th graders get less than **2 minutes** per question

Question 1 of 5: Math

Open the official guide on **page 23**:

The marbles question

(Jenny and Keiko)

NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions, p. 23

Write down your group's answer!

Source: NYC Public Schools / Pearson, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 1 of 5: Math

Open the official guide on **page 23**:

The marbles question

(Jenny and Keiko)

NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions, p. 23

D) 40

Jenny has $J = 2K$ marbles; after giving 5: $J - 5 = (K + 5) + 10$, so $J = 40$.

Source: NYC Public Schools / Pearson, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 2 of 5: Math

Open the official guide on **page 24**:

The rectangle question

(perimeter 510 cm, ratio 3:2)

NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions, p. 24

Write down your group's answer!

Source: NYC Public Schools / Pearson, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 2 of 5: Math

Open the official guide on **page 24**:

The rectangle question

(perimeter 510 cm, ratio 3:2)

NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions, p. 24

F) 153 cm by 102 cm

Sides $3x$ and $2x$: $10x = 510$, so $x = 51$.

Source: NYC Public Schools / Pearson, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 3 of 5: Math

Open the official guide on **page 25**:

The “lorgs and dalts” question

(exchanging money)

NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions, p. 25

Write down your group’s answer!

Source: NYC Public Schools / Pearson, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 3 of 5: Math

Open the official guide on **page 25**:

The “lorgs and dalts” question

(exchanging money)

NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions, p. 25

B) $52

140 lorgs = $20 and 16 dalts = $32.

Source: NYC Public Schools / Pearson, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 4 of 5: English

Open the official guide on **page 17**:

The Yankees paragraph

(a shift in verb tense)

NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions, p. 17

Write down your group's answer!

Source: NYC Public Schools / Pearson, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 4 of 5: English

Open the official guide on **page 17**:

The Yankees paragraph
(a shift in verb tense)

NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions, p. 17

A) Sentence 1

"meant" should be "means" or "will mean."

Source: NYC Public Schools / Pearson, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 5 of 5: English

Open the official guide on **page 18**:

The Airbnb paragraph

(an error in construction)

NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions, p. 18

Write down your group's answer!

Source: NYC Public Schools / Pearson, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

Question 5 of 5: English

Open the official guide on **page 18**:

The Airbnb paragraph
(an error in construction)

NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions, p. 18

F) Sentence 2

The opening phrase should describe the roommates, not the air mattresses.

Source: NYC Public Schools / Pearson, *NYC Guide to the SHSAT for 2027 Admissions* (2026).

How did you do?

- Which group got the most right?
- Which section was harder for you: English or Math? Why?
- Should one test decide who gets into the best public high schools?